In ASP.NET Core, Microsoft merged these two parallel stacks into a single ASP.NET Core MVC framework. Controllers in ASP.NET Core can generate both HTML and JSON/XML; there is no separation. Nevertheless, it's common for a controller to be dedicated to either HTML generation or JSON/XML. For that reason, the names *MVC controller* and *web API controller* are often used to refer to the two general types of controller: MVC for HTML and web API for JSON/XML.

In this book when I refer to web API controllers, I'm talking about standard ASP.NET Core controllers that are generating API responses. This may be described elsewhere as a web API application using MVC controllers or as a web API application. All three cases refer to the same concept: an HTTP API built using ASP.NET Core controllers.

Before we can get to comparisons, though, we should take a brief look at the ASP.NET Core MVC framework itself. Understanding the similarities and differences between MVC controllers and Razor Pages can be useful, as you'll likely find a use for MVC controllers at some point, even if you use Razor Pages most of the time.

19.2 Your first MVC web application

In this section you'll learn how to create your first MVC web application, which server-renders HTML pages using MVC controllers and Razor views. We use a template to create the app and compare the generated code to see how it differs from a Razor Pages application.

We'll again use a template to get an application up and running quickly. This time we'll use the ASP.NET Core Web App (Model-View-Controller) template. To create the application in Visual Studio, follow these steps:

1. Choose **File** > **New**.
2. In the **Create a new project** dialog box, select the **ASP.NET Core Web App (Model-View-Controller)** template.